

THE CAREGIVER'S JOURNAL

You Can't Pour from
an Empty Cup

Daily Reflections for Those
Who Care for Others

Daniel Tesfamariam

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RECOGNIZING CAREGIVER BURNOUT

Burnout doesn't happen overnight. It creeps in slowly.

Check any signs you've been experiencing:

- ☐ Feeling exhausted even after sleeping
- ☐ Resentment toward the person you care for
- ☐ Withdrawing from friends and activities
- ☐ Getting sick more often
- ☐ Feeling hopeless or trapped
- ☐ Neglecting your own health needs
- ☐ Difficulty sleeping or sleeping too much
- ☐ Increased irritability or anger
- ☐ Feeling unappreciated
- ☐ Loss of interest in things you used to enjoy
- ☐ Feeling like you have nothing left to give

How many did you check? ____

If 5+, you may be in burnout. This journal is for YOU.

COMPASSION FATIGUE ASSESSMENT

Rate each statement (1=Never, 5=Always):

1. I feel emotionally drained by caregiving	1	2	3	4	5
2. I have difficulty separating my problems from theirs	1	2	3	4	5
3. I feel guilty when I take time for myself	1	2	3	4	5
4. I have lost my sense of humor	1	2	3	4	5
5. I feel trapped in my caregiving role	1	2	3	4	5
6. I avoid talking about how I really feel	1	2	3	4	5
7. I feel angry that no one helps me	1	2	3	4	5
8. I have physical symptoms (headaches, pain)	1	2	3	4	5
9. I feel like I'm losing myself	1	2	3	4	5
10. I can't remember the last time I felt joy	1	2	3	4	5

Total Score: ____/50

10-20: Mild fatigue | 21-35: Moderate | 36-50: Severe

Today's date: _____

Retake this monthly to track changes.

DAILY JOURNAL - ENTRIES 1 & 2

ENTRY 1

Date: __/__/__

Stress Level (1-10): ____

Hours of sleep: ____

What I did for my loved one today:

What I did for MYSELF today:

One boundary I held: _____

One feeling I acknowledge: _____

Tomorrow I need help with: _____

ENTRY 2

Date: __/__/__

Stress Level (1-10): ____

Hours of sleep: ____

What I did for my loved one today:

What I did for MYSELF today:

One boundary I held: _____

One feeling I acknowledge: _____

Tomorrow I need help with: _____

DAILY JOURNAL - ENTRIES 3 & 4

ENTRY 3

Date: __/__/__

Stress Level (1-10): ____

Hours of sleep: ____

What I did for my loved one today:

What I did for MYSELF today:

One boundary I held: _____

One feeling I acknowledge: _____

Tomorrow I need help with: _____

ENTRY 4

Date: __/__/__

Stress Level (1-10): ____

Hours of sleep: ____

What I did for my loved one today:

What I did for MYSELF today:

One boundary I held: _____

One feeling I acknowledge: _____

Tomorrow I need help with: _____

DAILY JOURNAL - ENTRIES 5 & 6

ENTRY 5

Date: ____/____/____

Stress Level (1-10): ____

Hours of sleep: ____

What I did for my loved one today:

What I did for MYSELF today:

One boundary I held: _____

One feeling I acknowledge: _____

Tomorrow I need help with: _____

ENTRY 6

Date: ____/____/____

Stress Level (1-10): ____

Hours of sleep: ____

What I did for my loved one today:

What I did for MYSELF today:

One boundary I held: _____

One feeling I acknowledge: _____

Tomorrow I need help with: _____

DAILY JOURNAL - ENTRIES 7 & 8

ENTRY 7

Date: ____/____/____

Stress Level (1-10): ____

Hours of sleep: ____

What I did for my loved one today:

What I did for MYSELF today:

One boundary I held: _____

One feeling I acknowledge: _____

Tomorrow I need help with: _____

ENTRY 8

Date: ____/____/____

Stress Level (1-10): ____

Hours of sleep: ____

What I did for my loved one today:

What I did for MYSELF today:

One boundary I held: _____

One feeling I acknowledge: _____

Tomorrow I need help with: _____

DAILY JOURNAL - ENTRIES 9 & 10

ENTRY 9

Date: __/__/__

Stress Level (1-10): ____

Hours of sleep: ____

What I did for my loved one today:

What I did for MYSELF today:

One boundary I held: _____

One feeling I acknowledge: _____

Tomorrow I need help with: _____

ENTRY 10

Date: __/__/__

Stress Level (1-10): ____

Hours of sleep: ____

What I did for my loved one today:

What I did for MYSELF today:

One boundary I held: _____

One feeling I acknowledge: _____

Tomorrow I need help with: _____

DAILY JOURNAL - ENTRIES 11 & 12

ENTRY 11

Date: __/__/__

Stress Level (1-10): ____

Hours of sleep: ____

What I did for my loved one today:

What I did for MYSELF today:

One boundary I held: _____

One feeling I acknowledge: _____

Tomorrow I need help with: _____

ENTRY 12

Date: __/__/__

Stress Level (1-10): ____

Hours of sleep: ____

What I did for my loved one today:

What I did for MYSELF today:

One boundary I held: _____

One feeling I acknowledge: _____

Tomorrow I need help with: _____

DAILY JOURNAL - ENTRIES 13 & 14

ENTRY 13

Date: __/__/__

Stress Level (1-10): ____

Hours of sleep: ____

What I did for my loved one today:

What I did for MYSELF today:

One boundary I held: _____

One feeling I acknowledge: _____

Tomorrow I need help with: _____

ENTRY 14

Date: __/__/__

Stress Level (1-10): ____

Hours of sleep: ____

What I did for my loved one today:

What I did for MYSELF today:

One boundary I held: _____

One feeling I acknowledge: _____

Tomorrow I need help with: _____

DAILY JOURNAL - ENTRIES 15 & 16

ENTRY 15

Date: __/__/__

Stress Level (1-10): ____

Hours of sleep: ____

What I did for my loved one today:

What I did for MYSELF today:

One boundary I held: _____

One feeling I acknowledge: _____

Tomorrow I need help with: _____

ENTRY 16

Date: __/__/__

Stress Level (1-10): ____

Hours of sleep: ____

What I did for my loved one today:

What I did for MYSELF today:

One boundary I held: _____

One feeling I acknowledge: _____

Tomorrow I need help with: _____

DAILY JOURNAL - ENTRIES 17 & 18

ENTRY 17

Date: __/__/__

Stress Level (1-10): ____

Hours of sleep: ____

What I did for my loved one today:

What I did for MYSELF today:

One boundary I held: _____

One feeling I acknowledge: _____

Tomorrow I need help with: _____

ENTRY 18

Date: __/__/__

Stress Level (1-10): ____

Hours of sleep: ____

What I did for my loved one today:

What I did for MYSELF today:

One boundary I held: _____

One feeling I acknowledge: _____

Tomorrow I need help with: _____

DAILY JOURNAL - ENTRIES 19 & 20

ENTRY 19

Date: __/__/__

Stress Level (1-10): ____

Hours of sleep: ____

What I did for my loved one today:

What I did for MYSELF today:

One boundary I held: _____

One feeling I acknowledge: _____

Tomorrow I need help with: _____

ENTRY 20

Date: __/__/__

Stress Level (1-10): ____

Hours of sleep: ____

What I did for my loved one today:

What I did for MYSELF today:

One boundary I held: _____

One feeling I acknowledge: _____

Tomorrow I need help with: _____

DAILY JOURNAL - ENTRIES 21 & 22

ENTRY 21

Date: __/__/__

Stress Level (1-10): ____

Hours of sleep: ____

What I did for my loved one today:

What I did for MYSELF today:

One boundary I held: _____

One feeling I acknowledge: _____

Tomorrow I need help with: _____

ENTRY 22

Date: __/__/__

Stress Level (1-10): ____

Hours of sleep: ____

What I did for my loved one today:

What I did for MYSELF today:

One boundary I held: _____

One feeling I acknowledge: _____

Tomorrow I need help with: _____

DAILY JOURNAL - ENTRIES 23 & 24

ENTRY 23

Date: __/__/__

Stress Level (1-10): ____

Hours of sleep: ____

What I did for my loved one today:

What I did for MYSELF today:

One boundary I held: _____

One feeling I acknowledge: _____

Tomorrow I need help with: _____

ENTRY 24

Date: __/__/__

Stress Level (1-10): ____

Hours of sleep: ____

What I did for my loved one today:

What I did for MYSELF today:

One boundary I held: _____

One feeling I acknowledge: _____

Tomorrow I need help with: _____

DAILY JOURNAL - ENTRIES 25 & 26

ENTRY 25

Date: __/__/__

Stress Level (1-10): ____

Hours of sleep: ____

What I did for my loved one today:

What I did for MYSELF today:

One boundary I held: _____

One feeling I acknowledge: _____

Tomorrow I need help with: _____

ENTRY 26

Date: __/__/__

Stress Level (1-10): ____

Hours of sleep: ____

What I did for my loved one today:

What I did for MYSELF today:

One boundary I held: _____

One feeling I acknowledge: _____

Tomorrow I need help with: _____

DAILY JOURNAL - ENTRIES 27 & 28

ENTRY 27

Date: __/__/__

Stress Level (1-10): ____

Hours of sleep: ____

What I did for my loved one today:

What I did for MYSELF today:

One boundary I held: _____

One feeling I acknowledge: _____

Tomorrow I need help with: _____

ENTRY 28

Date: __/__/__

Stress Level (1-10): ____

Hours of sleep: ____

What I did for my loved one today:

What I did for MYSELF today:

One boundary I held: _____

One feeling I acknowledge: _____

Tomorrow I need help with: _____

DAILY JOURNAL - ENTRIES 29 & 30

ENTRY 29

Date: __/__/__

Stress Level (1-10): ____

Hours of sleep: ____

What I did for my loved one today:

What I did for MYSELF today:

One boundary I held: _____

One feeling I acknowledge: _____

Tomorrow I need help with: _____

ENTRY 30

Date: __/__/__

Stress Level (1-10): ____

Hours of sleep: ____

What I did for my loved one today:

What I did for MYSELF today:

One boundary I held: _____

One feeling I acknowledge: _____

Tomorrow I need help with: _____

RESPITE CARE PLANNING

Respite care = planned breaks from caregiving.

You NEED this. It's not optional - it's survival.

People who could help me take a break:

1. Name: _____ Can help with: _____

2. Name: _____ Can help with: _____

3. Name: _____ Can help with: _____

4. Name: _____ Can help with: _____

Professional respite options I can look into:

- Adult day care centers
- Home health aides (even a few hours/week)
- Respite care facilities (short stays)
- Volunteer visitor programs

My ideal respite schedule:

Daily break: ____ minutes doing _____

Weekly break: ____ hours doing _____

Monthly break: ____ day(s) doing _____

What's stopping me from taking breaks?

ASKING FOR HELP - SCRIPTS

Asking for help is HARD. Here are scripts you can use:

To a family member:

'I need help with [task]. Could you do this on [day]?''

To a friend:

'I'm struggling. I don't need you to fix it, just listen.'

To a sibling who isn't helping:

'I can't do this alone. Here's what I need from you: [specific task].'

To a doctor:

'I'm the caregiver and I'm burning out. What resources exist?'

My own script for asking for help:

Who I will ask: _____

What I will ask for: _____

When I will ask: _____

SETTING BOUNDARIES WITH FAMILY

Boundaries aren't selfish. They're how you survive this.

Boundaries I need to set:

With the person I care for:

With other family members:

With my own expectations:

With work/outside obligations:

Boundary phrases I can use:

'I love you AND I need rest right now.'

'I can do X but I cannot do Y today.'

'That's not something I'm able to take on.'

'I need 30 minutes of uninterrupted time.'

MY SUPPORT NETWORK

Map out the people and resources in your life:

EMOTIONAL SUPPORT (people who listen):

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____

PRACTICAL SUPPORT (people who can DO things):

1. _____ Can help with: _____
2. _____ Can help with: _____
3. _____ Can help with: _____

PROFESSIONAL SUPPORT:

Doctor: _____

Therapist/Counselor: _____

Support Group: _____

Social Worker: _____

ONLINE/COMMUNITY RESOURCES:

- Caregiver Action Network: caregiveraction.org
- AARP Caregiver Support: aarp.org/caregiving
- Local Area Agency on Aging: _____

SELF-COMPASSION EXERCISES

You deserve the same kindness you give others.

Exercise 1: The Friend Test

What would you say to a friend in your situation?

Now say that same thing to yourself.

Exercise 2: Permission Slips

I give myself permission to:

- ☐ feel tired
- ☐ say no
- ☐ ask for help
- ☐ feel angry
- ☐ rest without guilt

Exercise 3: Loving-Kindness for Yourself

Repeat: 'May I be safe. May I be healthy.

May I be at peace. May I know I am enough.'

How did that feel? (circle)

Awkward / Emotional / Comforting / Nothing / Other: ____

EMERGENCY BURNOUT PLAN

Fill this out NOW. Use it when you hit your breaking point.

Signs I'm at my breaking point:

Person who can take over immediately:

Name: _____ Phone: _____

My emergency self-care plan:

Step 1 (right now): _____

Step 2 (today): _____

Step 3 (this week): _____

Place I can go to decompress:

Professional I can call:

**Remember: You cannot care for someone else
if you have completely depleted yourself.
Getting help is NOT abandoning them.**

WEEKLY REFLECTION

Take a few minutes each week to check in with yourself.

Week of: _____

Overall stress this week (1-10): ____

Moments I felt overwhelmed:

Moments I felt okay or even good:

Did I ask for help this week? Y / N

If yes, how did it go?

One thing I'll do differently next week:

Something kind I did for myself:

GRATITUDE & GRIEF

Caregiving often means grieving while caregiving.

Both gratitude and grief can exist at the same time.

What I'm grieving:

(lost time, changed relationship, my old life, their health...)

What I'm grateful for:

A memory that makes me smile:

Something I want them to know:

YOUR CAREGIVER BILL OF RIGHTS

As a caregiver, you have the RIGHT to:

- * Take care of myself without feeling guilty
- * Seek help from others even if my loved one objects
- * Maintain parts of my own life that don't include caregiving
- * Get angry, be sad, and express difficult feelings
- * Reject any attempt to manipulate me through guilt
- * Receive consideration, affection, and acceptance
- * Take pride in what I accomplish
- * Be treated with respect by those I care for
- * Make mistakes without feeling like a failure
- * Protect my individuality and my right to a life of my own
- * Expect and demand improvements in our support system
- * Say 'I'm done for today' without explanation

Which right do you most need to claim today?

MONTHLY CHECK-IN

Month: _____

My physical health this month (1-10): ____

My emotional health this month (1-10): ____

My relationships this month (1-10): ____

Biggest challenge this month:

How I handled it:

Something that brought me joy:

My goals for next month:

For my loved one: _____

For myself: _____

For my health: _____

Am I getting the support I need? Y / N

If no, what needs to change?

YOU ARE DOING SOMETHING INCREDIBLE.

And you deserve care too.

You are not alone in this journey.

You are not failing.

You are human.

Caregiver Support:

Caregiver Action Network: 1-855-227-3640

AARP Caregiving Helpline: 1-877-333-5885

With gratitude, Daniel Tesfamariam